

Tourist Trap

T.S

Three sightseers on Mars decide to drive out and explore the desert. What they find transforms their holiday into an abhorrent struggle for survival.

Zara let the keys spin around her finger, only looking up once Blake had paid.

"Are you sure we should do this Z?" He whispered, making sure Carla couldn't hear and interject. Zara knew why. Carla was a direct problem in ensuring Blake captured her full attention. In more ways than one, although he didn't exactly know that. It wasn't cheating or anything, they had only met a week ago.

"Yes I'm sure. I've seen everything of Catalan. The large metallic structures that blend together, the 'alien' carnivals, the bubble buildings. I'm sick of this man-made crap. It's time we go explore the desert and see what Mars really has to offer."

Blake grimaced.

"It's untamed terrain. There are horror stories of missing and mangled tourists, I'm just not sure it's a good idea for us to go, especially alone."

Zara smiled and raised her voice.

"What do you think Carla?"

The brunette fidgeted.

"Blake makes a good point. It's not the smartest idea."

Zara licked her lips.

"It'll be a grand adventure. We've already paid, and I've got the keys right here. Are you going to follow me or what?"

It didn't take long for Carla to change her mind.

"You're right girl. You're crazy but you're fun.

Following you is something I'll remember for the rest of my life."

Carla walked through the doors to the shops interior garage. Zara cocked her head at Blake. He pouted. He had been doing that a lot. Almost trying to control her. Not in a negative way, but just enough to make Zara feel like it was time to move on. She had given him all the signs that they were was just two people having a bit of fun.

Sure, Zara hadn't been explicitly upfront about it.

Then again, she didn't need to be.

"Alright, I'll come." Blake sighed.

They followed Carla out, stepping into a large overhanging area, filled with dune buggies of varying colours.

Zara clicked the button on her keys, and a brown one beeped in recognition. After putting the packs of water and food in the boot, they strapped themselves in, with Zara sitting in the driver's seat.

All at once they tapped their necks with two fingers. It was like they were pressing a button.

Plastic, round bulbs grew out of their necks, the extra oxygen it provided rushing into their brain. They placed hats on their heads, a cap for Blake, straw bonnets for the girls.

Zara pumped the accelerator, making the buggy sing loudly.

"Let's go!" She yelled, as she powered out of the open garage. The buggy's large dirt wheels began churning through the orange sand, and they sped off towards the dunes, ready to explore the Martian wilderness.

Nothing had ever sparked Zara's enthusiasm more than the hole.

The olive-skinned girl was a fighter; her problem was that she had a habit of combatting that which was supposed to help her.

Disregarding her parents' attempt to prod her into a vocation, Zara left university to lead a path of social justice. Months of protest made her realise that she could

only make genuine change through the power mechanisms of corporations. Within five years, she had shot up the ranks, her personality and doggedness to succeed not just exceeding but demolishing all expectations.

It was when she finally had that moment, to change social structures, to help those in need, that was when she hesitated.

Not because she had been corrupted by the money and ideologies of those around her.

It was because she hadn't been doing it for the poor. She hadn't even been doing it for herself. She was doing it to fight the world.

She needed something more. She left and began travelling, to see the world she apparently had such a need to attack. And when that got boring, she looked to the stars, and caught a ship to Mars, to see the famous city of Catalan. The thrills of people, structures and nature fascinated her yet quickly got old.

It was the same as Earth, man's design was a mimicry, nothing could be original.

It made her feel unfulfilled.

Until she saw the hole.

When she stepped out of the buggy, the size of it almost floored her. It was the width and length of a skyscraper; a black maw entrenched in the sand. They had only seen it because along the edges were jagged rocks, crisscrossing around each other.

Zara placed a hand on the obsidian rock. It was thick and long with puckered marks that blemished the black.

"Great," came a voice behind her. "It's a hole. Can we carry on, we still have a bit to go before sunset."

Blake's descent from irritation to being downright rude had not been lost on her.

Zara tried to distract him.

"Blake these natural phenomena are why we are here. It's a hole. But how big is it? Where does it lead to? Do you think a meteor made it?"

"We should find out!" Carla smiled and the two of them began moving forward. With careful precision, they stepped onto the rocks and jumped past them. The ground was steep here. It was like they were standing on a hill, yellow sand descending into the darkness below.

Carla looked backwards, a frown now appearing on her

"Come on Carla, what are you waiting for? Blake, get down here already!" Zara encouraged.

"Z, haven't you heard of cave diving?" Blake yelled from above.

Zara didn't believe that dignified a reply. They weren't that stupid; they were just having a look.

"It's so dark down there." Carla shivered. The floor was very angled, although they weren't in danger of losing their footing.

"Z, come back. It looks dangerous." She turned to see Blake behind the rocks, his fingers tapping nervously. He still hadn't climbed over.

"I'm only going to say this once. You can stay up there. We, will have this adventure without you." Zara flashed a smile at Carla who bravely stepped forward.

Blake climbed over the slabs.

"Do you see that Zara?" Carla whispered. The hot sun was unnaturally dim, and the shadows of the rocks rose over them.

Before Zara could reply, she slipped. Her heart rose up her throat, until Carla grabbed her shoulder, halting her tumble to oblivion.

"Are you alright?" Blake called down.

"Yes, I don't know I was just ..." They all yelled in unison as the steep ground they stood on ... shifted. Yellow grains began falling down the hole.

The two girls stared at each other for half a second, before beginning to sprint, legs pounding into the ground as they ran back up the few yards they had traversed. However, what had taken them seconds to go down became next to impossible to return back up. The ground was fighting back, tilting so much that what was once a hill was now becoming a wall. Blake was waved at the top, one arm wrapped around the rocks, reaching down with the other. Zara was down on all fours, galloping as she climbed. She heard a scream that quickly faded as Carla fell, and it spurred her to jump, her legs somehow gaining purchase in the sand. After an agonising second, she felt her hand collide with Blake's, the clap of their palms calming her raging heart, if only for a second.

"Where's Carla? I can't see her." Blake strained.

"She's gone." The words came out easily, but Zara felt cold inside.

"What? Oh fuck. What do we do, I can't ... I don't want to ..."

"Blake! Snap out of it. We need to focus. I'm going to climb onto you, so you can put both hands on the rock. Then I'll climb up you and lift you up.

Got it?"

Blake whimpered. The sweat covering his hand was making their grip precarious.

Without waiting for a response, Zara managed to wrap her legs around his hips, and after letting go of his hand, began climbing. Blake muttered curses yet held, both hands now had a good grip on the slabs. Zara managed to get her feet on his shoulders. She grabbed the rocks and grunted in surprise.

"What?" Blake looked up.

The slabs had grown and moved. Where before they had crisscrossed on the edges of the hole, now they were metres longer, and arched over *it*. Zara hadn't noticed them shift, but now, they were dangling in the air above the dark maw beneath.

"Maybe ... it will ... take us to the other side." Zara panted.

Their faces were right next to each as their feet spun in the air. Blake had stopped cursing, but his eyes were moving wildly, teeth grinding down. Then, he screamed.

One hand dropped to his side, curled into a tight fist. It was bleeding. Zara looked up to see that a bloody spike had erupted out of the puckered rock Blake had been gripping.

With a helpless look, Zara watched another barb pierce through Blake's other hand, and his palm dropped from the rock. He fell screaming, until there was only silence.

Zara panted with fear. She howled with pain as a spike drilled into one hand. Zara let go.

She wailed as she was engulfed in the blackness of the hole.

Until that too was silenced.

Zara opened her eyes. She was lying down on her back. Her hands and legs were touching something slippery, a porous substance that clung to her flesh. She tried to rise and failed.

Not only did the ground hold her slightly, it also shuddered whenever she moved her arms, providing no purchase for her to get up. After a few attempts, she managed to turn herself onto her belly. The ground was some sort of goo. It sucked greedily at her cheeks and nose, the moistness of it disgusting. Zara turned her face to the side. With a groan she flopped herself back onto her back.

Zara looked up at the sky. It was as black as the hole they had fallen into. She had no idea how long they had been falling for.

They.

The realisation made her cry out.

"Blake? Carla!"

"We're here." Carla replied.

"Both of us." Blake strangled the words out.

"Do you know where we are? How long have I been out?" It was agonising that Zara couldn't even lean forward to look at them, even if she wasn't able to make out their figures in the blackness.

"I've been awake for a while."

Zara was about to respond, when she noticed that soft rays of light were beginning to penetrate the darkness.

Deep orange illuminated their predicament. Funnily enough, the light didn't come from directly above, but from the edges of the walls around them. When she squinted, she thought that maybe there were orifices in the wall that emitted the sunshine.

The sky was still eternally black.

When Zara tilted her head left, she saw Blake lying down like her. Carla was somehow sitting, her knees crossed together. The 'ground' was transparent, and looking around it was circular, as if they were in a round bowl. The light was reflecting from it, the sun's rays distorting into the colours of the rainbow, as if it was hitting a bubble. She could not see anything through the bubble, below was just more darkness.

"What should we do?" Zara asked. She looked at Blake, then averted her gaze.

It had been too quick for her to give it thought, but his fear on the rocks had been akin to a breakdown.

The tears in his eyes did not mix well with how bloodshot they were.

"Got any ideas Carla?"

"We could have fallen for hours. I don't see how we can climb up. Maybe someone will try and rescue us, but I don't think so.

I've never heard of a hole that people fall in too on Mars.

Which probably means no-one has lived to let anyone know about it." Carla's damning proclamation was emotionless.

"We are fucked." Blake whimpered.

Zara clenched her teeth.

"Guys we can try do something, come on."

Carla's words were cold.

"There is nothing we can do. No escape. No rescue.

Nothing. There is no point. Just let us pass in peace."

Zara stared at the blackness to try swallow her guilt. It didn't work.

What was she to do? Was it really the end?

God damn it, she was not going to die here, in a stupid bubble, without doing something.

She tried to work out how to move. The bubble's surface was slippery and the way it held her made every movement tough. Not impossible though.

She could roll. She kept flopping on her face and back but bared her teeth and continued. Carla made no comment.

Blake made plenty. His whimpers soon became background noise.

Eventually, she worked it out. By lying on her stomach, she could use the swimming move, breast-stroke, to move herself forward. She kicked her shoes into the bubble and thrust forward with her arms and chest.

Zara *moved*. She whooped in exhilaration, then ran into a new problem. She could move forward, but due to the slope of the bubble, eventually she would start sliding backwards.

Complications exist to help optimise your solution.

As Zara slid backwards, she twisted to face the opposite way and began to breast-stroke with her slide, successfully using the velocity to get further up the other slope.

It was a swing. Zara giggled, momentarily forgetting about their situation. After surging back and forth over the bubble, she managed to reach one of the orifices that exuded the sunlight. At this point she was almost at a 90-degree angle, so she only had a second to look into the light before

sliding away. It was bright, but Zara thought that in that brief moment, she could make out the foundations of a tunnel.

She swung back up to confirm. Yes, it seemed like a round hole with a rocky bottom. It was certainly large enough to crawl into.

They had a route out of here!

Zara arrested her slide, bursting at the seams to tell her companions.

Carla was sitting still, she hadn't moved.

Blake was another story. He lay on his stomach, face held up, cheeks twitching and eyes blinking.

Thick bushels of hair of his own hair lay on the ground. Until they turned transparent and were sucked into the bubble. Zara winced when she saw him rip out another strand, bald spots were now populating the front of his temple.

Blake needed guidance, someone to take charge and keep him calm. They would get out of this.

All of them.

"Listen. I've found a way out."

Carla dropped her face to her chest.

"Come on! Think positive. I can get us out of this, I swear!" Zara shone her winning smile on Blake.

He stared at her, one hand grabbing another piece of hair, his face turnING red as he began to pull.

"Like how you got us into this?"

"Blake, I..."

"No!" He interrupted. "We are fucked. There is nothing ... I don't get ... Ahhh!"

Zara rubbed her hand down her face at the outburst.

"Carla, can you help?"

When there was no response, Zara slid over.

"You need to relax Blake. Calm down." She put a gentle hand on his shoulder.

"Don't touch me!" Blake slapped forward with a backhand, which Zara ducked, quickly breastroking out of his range.

"I need to get out of here." He whispered.

"Just listen to me, I'll get you out of here!"

Blake didn't listen. He pressed his fingers into the sides of his forehead.

"Need to get out, get out, OUT!" He screamed. Still lying on his front, he reached one hand into his pants pocket, to spring out a pocketknife.

"Woah, Blake. You're angry. You're upset. No-one makes good decisions when they're upset. Put the knife down."

Blake pointed it at her in threat, then switched his grip, so the edge was facing down.

"I'm getting out."

With a plunge he pierced the bubble. Zara held her breath.

Nothing happened. Even Blake's frantic behaviour quelled, as he looked at the slice. He put a hand through it, waving it underneath the bubble. As he did so, Zara felt a tremble. The bubble was softly quaking. It puzzled her.

Until she heard the chatter. The sound made her wince, a screeching noise that reminded her of a knife and fork scraping the bottom of the plate. Eventually, she saw the perpetrators. Underneath the bubble, clinging to it with their feet and pincers, were red insects. Their multiple legs and arachnid bodies were ant-like. But they were much larger, almost as big as a cat, and their heads were triangular, ending in a point. Dozens marched in a line to the slash Blake had made. He squealed when he saw them, yet they ignored him. Four went on either side of the gash and pressed their heads to the bubble. As they moved their chattering grew louder.

The bubble was healed.

"Trying to stop me huh? I'm out I tell you. OUT!" Blake repeated. He started swiping left and right, cutting much larger gashes. The ants tried to repair the damage, until his

knife struck one in the head. Green blood sprayed out, and it wobbled before falling into the abyss.

The other ants moved away, their clicking urgent.

A retreat, not a withdrawal. They remained underneath the bubble just far enough from Blake's maddening blows.

"Got you!" The man's cries were nothing like the Blake Zara had thought she had known. His face was flush, his shoulders trembling. He began slashing at the bubble again, the wound getting larger.

Zara breast-stroked a bit closer.

"Come on Blake. Please calm down."

His cuts stopped. He looked at her, head tilted sideways. The knife was suddenly pointing at her.

"Are. You. Telling me. To calm down?" He stabbed at her, extending his arm. Zara dodged, causing Blake to fall forward.

Into the hole he had made.

With a squeal, he managed to catch himself before he dropped through. He was now upside down, his hips wedged into the gap as his legs flailed. Zara realised with a stab of fear that the erratic movements were sliding him through.

"Blake! Stop moving or you'll fall!" She commanded.

Blake ceased his struggle. He turned his head to her, his features were distorted through the surface of the bubble.

"Please. Help me."

"Throw me the knife Blake."

He looked at the blade in his hand, and after carefully pushing it past his hips, dropped it on onto the topside of the bubble. Zara picked it up.

"Thank you. Now, and don't bite my head off at this.

The most important thing you need to do is to stay calm. If you go crazy again, you might kill us both.

Got it?"

She took no response as acquiescence and began moving forward. When something stopped her.

"Oh no."

The screaming returned when Blake registered the danger.

Zara was frozen still. Later, she tried to make herself feel better by saying that Blake had dug his own grave.

Unfortunately, if you're standing next to someone who shoots themselves in the head, you won't forget washing their blood off your face.

Behind Blake, on the underside of the bubble, were two giant ants. They were triple the size of their counterparts. A

green hue circled their red bodies, and their heads were two long flat ends, a dual-pronged fork. They made their way to the howling man. Blake used his fists to try ward them off.

It was futile. When he swung at one, his knuckles clung off its armour. The other surged forward and put its prongs around his head, clamping tight. Violet fungus wrapped around the prongs, and when they touched Blake's skin, the veins throughout his body popped purple.

He stopped flailing, limbs were rigid, as if he was paralysed. It didn't stop his tongue, despite his head being in the middle of the prongs, Zara could hear his excruciating screams.

The smaller, worker ants moved forward, chattering to themselves.

They began to repair the bubble, ignoring the body in their way, crawling around Blake. As they repaired the surface, the bubble began congealing over Blake's skin.

Zara vomited.

In an instant, Blake's stomach and hips had separated, his legs and bottom flopping onto her side of the bubble. There was no blood, but the white bone of his spine was exposed to the elements. His head was still clamped in the ant's maw, upside down in the darkness. That's when the silvery, fluorescent bubble began *creeping up his skin*. The

pale sheen started with his spine and stomach, flowed up his arms, took control of his neck. In place of Blake was the bubble, its slippery mesh a perfect statue of the man's top half. Until the ant crushed its prongs together. The bubble statue popped and its substance flowed opposite to gravity, splashing upwards to assimilate back into the surface.

His separated hips and legs flopped uselessly on the topside of the bubble. Until that too was consumed.

All that remained was his memory. That, and the screams.

They just weren't his.

"I'm going to try the orifice. See the wall where the light is emerging from?

You coming?"

Carla made no response. Zara had tried talking to her, to say something after the grisly end of their companion.

Carla gave her nothing. It was maddening. She breast-stroked forward, getting close to the woman.

"I need a reply. I said. Are you *fucking* coming?"

Carla stared at her. There was no anger in the gaze. Her eyes were empty, lips soft and relaxed.

"So, what Carla? You just going to sit here and die? You know what's going to happen right, if you didn't just stare at

the ground when Blake was brutalised. You're going to become part of this thing. Is that what you want?"

It wasn't a guess. When Zara had stayed in place for too long, the slippery surface had begun to harden around her body. She hadn't slept yet. She wasn't sure if she would be able to move again if she did.

"I don't think there's another option." Carla finally began speaking.

"You're being stupid. Help yourself and survive!"

"Zara. Have you wondered where we actually are? Truly questioned it?"

We are in some sort of natural cave, with a surface that I have never heard of. There is a species of ant here that humankind didn't know existed on Mars.

How does that happen? Only if no one lives to tell the tale. Blake told me that the rocks spiked his hand.

Everything suggests that we are dealing with a predator. There is no escaping, our lives are already over."

Zara stared. She barely knew the girl. Yet Zara had heard that voice throughout her life.

"Nothing is inevitable. You just need to fight."

"Peace is better than war. Dying is a scary thing. At least I have a second to appreciate my life before it is over."

"Who are you? No-one talks like that."

Carla nodded.

"Probably. But now, it's the only way I can look forward. Zara.

You don't understand.

I'm already dead."

For the first time, Carla's voice twinged with emotion, dropping to a whisper. Zara frowned. She breast-stroked forward and pushed the sitting woman. Carla didn't move.

"I'm not a fatalist Zara. It already has its hooks in me." Carla tried raising her hands. For a second there was movement, and her fingers pulled up from the ground. The bubble followed, thick strands of the goo clinging to her hands until they were yanked back down with a smack.

Zara saw it all with clarity. How Carla's skin was beginning to gleam, how her fingers were becoming webbed, a pale surface materialising between the knuckles.

A tear slid down Carla's cheek. It was as translucent as the bubble.

"Just. Let me go."

Zara bowed her head at the plea. Her heart raged, ached for her to do something, to fight and save her friend. Instead, she listened to the request.

Something deep inside of Zara cracked as she waited. She moved from side to side every now and then, ensuring that she didn't stick to the surface.

It allowed her to look away.

Once the bubble began transforming Carla, it did so at rapid pace. Soon her whole body was a silver sculpture. It had completely consumed her.

Her body melted to join the surface, leaving Zara all alone.

All alone.

She was the only one left. And she was losing time. She needed food, water, sleep. Before long, her body would shut down on her.

Zara looked down at her hand. She still had the knife.

She stared at to the dark emptiness above her, raising the blade to her own neck.

What was the point of fighting?

Zara hadn't just failed to save Carla; she had failed to do anything of meaning. She had led two people to their deaths.

For what?

For whom?

That was when Zara focused on the sunlight coming out of the orifice. Despite the hole's void, light had still managed to penetrate through the veil.

Fighting made Zara who she was. It was natural. She focused all her emotions, her rage, her guilt, her fear, and unleashed it into a vehement scream. Zara would not give up.

Being consumed was not an option.

After a deep breath, she began breast-stroking from side to side, looking at the orifices that exhumed the protruding light. It was going to be difficult.

She would have to swing up with enough momentum to reach it and manage to slice a hole she could fit through before the ants fixed it up.

After a minute, she was beginning to slide incredibly fast, and with satisfaction, she managed to cut the mesh protecting the orifice. After accelerating back and forth, she made her slice a gash. Adrenaline pumped through her as she kept making the slashes in the bubble wider. That was when she heard the chattering.

As she looked at the line of ants, she noticed to the detriment of her plans, that the workers were accompanied by

the two soldier ants. After one more slice, with a yell she slid back and forth to grab the orifice. The tough black rock cut into her hands. Despite the pain, Zara held.

She was suspended in the air, legs dangling wildly. Zara pushed her head through the bubble into the orifice, the afternoon light warm on her face. With excruciating effort, she pulled her shoulders in, crying out when they scraped the sides. When she dragged in her hips, she managed to sit, body screaming at the ordeal.

"I did it."

Quickly dragging her legs in, Zara took in her surroundings. She was in a tunnel, and while it was vertical, she could easily climb up, the walls providing ample hand and foot holds. Just before leaving, she looked down at the bubble she had escaped from.

It shimmered, the rainbow lights bouncing around Zara's vision. What was it?

Was it a predator? A piece of geography? Could she even hate it? As horrible as it was, it was just natural. Would you blame Mt Everest for the deaths it caused?

Zara put one hand on the wall and began climbing. After scaling about a metre, Zara had to stop and breathe. The work was difficult; she was using muscles she hadn't even known

existed. The break allowed her to look down. Goosebumps broke out over her body.

The soldiers were in the tunnel. And they were following her.

"Come on Zara, climb!"

She scampered up another metre in her haste.

They scuttled faster.

She heard their feet clatter into the rocky walls and squealed when one the soldier's prongs clamped on her leg. She screamed in pain when it began squeezing. Until she felt nothing. Her vision clouded up, and her head tilted forward. She saw the veins in her arms had turned purple, and after they popped, she let go of the rock, releasing herself into the air.

Her body thumped onto the ground. It should have broken her bones. Maybe it did, Zara felt nothing.

A voice faintly echoed in her mind, screaming at her to do ... something. It didn't make sense. She had no control. As she lay, the soldier ants pushed her body, and it fell back into the bubble.

There she remained. Her whole life had been a constant battle. Was it finally time to give up?

The goo began to consume her. She saw her skin slowly transform into the translucent bubble. It felt like a drug stimulating her.

It pissed Zara off. Rage tickled her throat. Nothing had beaten her like the bubble.

Nothing ever would.

Once the paralysis had dissipated, she tried to move. Zara moaned as she struggled to lift an arm. Yet despite the goo's incessant demands, she managed to pull her forearm out of the air. She wagged it above her face in exhilaration. Then she took out her knife and cut through the silver.

Zara heard the chattering off the ants. They were too slow. Once she managed to cut through, her body fell out of the bubble. The darkness swallowed her as the air cut through her hair.

After she was gone, the ants repaired their bubble. It's surface wobbled. It was amused at its failure to consume the woman. Prey was always different in some ways.

They were also very similar.

They were all delicious. And there were always more to come.

The End

